

Cardio Guide

Types of Cardio

Modality	Purpose	Typical Prescription
Steady-State (jog, cycle, row, brisk walk)	Aerobic base, active recovery	20-45 min at 60-70% max HR
Zone 2 Cardio	Mitochondrial/aerobic efficiency, fat oxidation	30-60 min at conversational pace
HIIT (sprints, bike intervals)	VO2 max, time-efficient conditioning	8-20 min, work:rest 1:1 to 1:3
LISS (low-intensity steady state)	Low-fatigue calorie expenditure	30-60 min, very light effort

Estimating Max Heart Rate & Zones

A common estimate: Max HR = 220 - age (rough approximation; individual variation exists).

Zone 2 is roughly 60-70% of max HR; HIIT work intervals are typically 85%+ of max HR.

Cardio & Strength Training Together

Cardio and strength can be combined in the same program without interference for most recreational goals if total volume/recovery is managed.

If muscle/strength is the priority, keep intense cardio sessions separated from leg training days or place cardio after lifting, not before.

For pure endurance goals, cardio volume can take priority with 2-3 shorter strength sessions per week to maintain muscle.

Cardio for Fat Loss vs. Health

For fat loss, cardio contributes to the calorie deficit but is secondary to diet; use it to comfortably increase the deficit without extreme food restriction.

For general cardiovascular health, guidelines commonly cite ~150 minutes/week of moderate-intensity activity or ~75 minutes/week of vigorous activity.